And go on cruelly conspiring against the people

To continue exploiting them… And then Fidel arrived!

The party was over:

The Comandante arrived and ordered it to stop!

Many of the actors and events in Cuba's revolutionary history have been elevated to mythical status, not only in Cuba, but around the world. In 2000, *Time Magazine* named Che Guevara as one of the 100 most important figures of the previous century. "His figure stares out at us from coffee mugs and posters, jingles at the end of key rings and jewelry, pops up in rock songs and operas and art shows," *Time* notes.[35] In Cuba, it is impossible to pass a day without confronting Che's image. Schoolchildren chant "¡Seremos como el Che!"– we will be like Che – to launch the school day (Figure 1.2).[36] The United States has its American Revolution, Declaration of Independence, George Washington, Abraham Lincoln, and Statue of Liberty as symbols of what many believe to be the essence of the country and its national identity. Cuba elevates figures from its nineteenth-century revolutionary war against Spain to heroic status, and it does the same with many of the people and events central to the 1959 Revolution. None quite reaches the iconic status of José Martí, whose bust is ubiquitous in public places and whose name graces Havana's international airport and the country's national library. But the leaders of the 1959 Revolution have also achieved outsized status in Cuba.

Figure 1.2 Print by Cuban artist Sandra Ramos, "Seremos Como El Che" (We will be like Che)

Source: Sandra Ramos, 1993, "Seremos Como El Che". Etching/aquatint 40 × 50 cm. © Sandra Ramos

Image not available in this digital edition

Che Guevara became the most mythologized leader for several reasons. Unlike the other revolutionary leaders, he was not Cuban. Rather, he was a Marxist physician from Argentina, who left his country to devote his life to the revolutionary cause. He was also something of a revolutionary philosopher, leaving his mark on Marxist thought with his